

Session 26: Offerings at the Door of the Garden

Key Takeaways

- Cain and Abel introduce the biblical pattern of shepherds representing reliance on God and farmers representing self-reliance.
- Yahweh's favor can be a cause of jealousy and danger.
- Textual clues indicate that the brothers were offering sacrifices at the door to the garden in Eden.

Cain and Abel's Offering: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 4:2-7

Cain and Abel's Offering

- a 2b and **Abel** was a shepherd of flocks,
b but **Cain** was a tiller of the ground,
c 3 and it came from the end of days
b' and **Cain**
brought from the fruit of the ground
an offering to Yahweh.
a' 4 and **Abel**
also he brought from the firstborn of his flock
and from their fat portions,

- a and Yahweh gazed
b upon **Abel** and for his offering;
b' 5 but upon **Cain** and upon his offering
a' he did not gaze.

- a and there was **heat-anger** to Cain,
b and his **face fell**,
6 and Yahweh said to Cain,
a' **Why is there heat-anger to you?**
b' and why has your **face fallen** ?
a 7 If you **do good**,
b **won't there be lifting up**,
a' and if you **do not do good**,
b' **at the door, sin is a croucher**,

~ c' and its desire is for you,
c' but you can **rule** it."

The Cain and Abel Story. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom Adam to Noah (2020).

Farmers vs. Shepherds, the City vs. the Wilderness

Cain and Abel are first introduced by their economic and cultural domains. Cain is a farmer who works the ground, and Abel is a shepherd who works among migrating flocks. These two vocations have important associations throughout the biblical narrative.

Farming and Cities

Organized agriculture in the ancient Near East was associated with the world's first empires (Babylon and Egypt), where slave labor and infrastructure provided the groundwork for mass farming. It's no accident that Cain will become associated with the first cities in the Bible ([Gen. 4:17](#)) and the advent of technology and civilization ([Gen. 4:20-22](#)).

Shepherding and the Desert

Shepherds who migrated with their grazing animals were nomads that lived on the borders of urban society. They tended to be viewed as lower class (though they could produce great wealth) and outside the value systems of the great cities and empires (shepherds were viewed as despicable by urban Egyptians ([Gen. 43:32](#); [46:34](#))).

Generally, Yahweh identifies himself with the shepherd underdog throughout the Bible and consistently reveals himself to people in the desert, to shepherds outside the imperial systems of organized human power and prestige.

- Abraham the shepherd is called out of the cities of Babylon ("Ur of the Chaldeans") and Haran in Syria ([Gen. 11:31-12:4](#)).
- Isaac and Jacob and his many sons are all shepherds living on the edge of urban centers in the land of Canaan.
- Moses meets Yahweh in the desert of Sinai while shepherding his flock ([Exod. 3](#)).
- Yahweh forms the people of Israel by leading them out of Egypt (where they farm and build cities) and establishing them as his covenant people in the Sinai desert.
- Israel's first true king, David, was a shepherd ([1 Sam. 16:11](#)), while the illegitimate king, Saul, was a farmer of the field ([1 Sam. 11:5](#)).
- Yahweh himself is portrayed as Israel's shepherd ([Ps. 23:1-6](#)), and he dwells in a tent ([2 Sam. 7:6](#)).

This contrast continues throughout the rest of the Hebrew Bible, and it is introduced in the Cain and Abel story in order to prepare us for what happens next. It should not surprise us that God favors the shepherd and that the "city boy" (or "farmer boy") is the negative character.

Yahweh's Favor for Abel but Not for Cain

The narrative is very spare, but it's precise in directing the reader's attention that what we're supposed to notice in the Cain and Abel narrative.

The Nature of the Offerings

Cain brings "the fruit of the ground." Cain is, like Adam his father, a tiller of the ground, which has been cursed. Cain's offering, while legitimate, is an undifferentiated vegetable and grain bundle.

Abel's offering is "from the firstborn of the flock, and from the fat portions." Notice the extra detail devoted to the description of Abel's offering, which highlights two layers of value: (1) the firstborn of the flock (the greatest symbolic value), and (2) the fat portions (the tastiest and most nutritious portions). The narrative implies a direct contrast here between Cain's bundled veggies and Abel's carefully selected and valuable animal offering.

"By giving the first-born and the best of the animal (i.e. the fat), Abel would be understood as having given everything to God."

Hess, Richard (1992). "Abel." [*The Anchor Yale Bible Dictionary, A-C, Vol. 1*](#). Yale University Press.

While both offerings are legitimate (grain and animal offerings are both described in the sacrificial rules of Leviticus 1-7), the lavish value ascribed to Abel's offering makes Cain's gift pale in comparison. But the fault isn't simply in the ingredients of the offering but what they indicated about the character of the one offering.

God Does Not "Reject" Cain

God's favor on Abel does not constitute a rejection of Cain, though he seems to experience it as such. God immediately reaches out to Cain, continues a long dialogue with him, and tells him that this moment is not permanent.

God tells Cain the way to favor: "do what is good." The implication is that God can discern, somehow, in Cain's offering that all is not well in his heart, mind, and character. So he works with Cain and invites him to do the right thing to experience divine favor.

"The issue in Genesis 4 is one of ethics, not of sacrificial ingredient ... Nonetheless, there exists a possibility that a comparative ethical value is reflected in the quality of the sacrifices offered ... With the same ingredients, the human roles could have been reversed ... Cain would have selected the best of what the earth can offer, and Abel would killed an animal picked gingerly from the heard ... The emphasis is not on the ingredient of the sacrifices but on the disposition of the one offering."

LaCocque, Andre (2008). [*Onslaught Against Innocence: Cain, Abel, and the Yahwist*](#). Cascade Books.

The Firstborn Rivalry and Yahweh

Cain's birth story draws attention to him as the firstborn. His mother boasts of her ability to "create" a man, and this man goes on to take the place of Adam as a "worker of the ground."

Cain is also the first to bring an offering, as the patriarch or firstborn male always does as their prerogative. The firstborn was to be acknowledged as the one who received the greater share of the inheritance (Deut. 21:17) as the father's representative (Gen. 49:3). In Genesis, the male head of the family offers sacrifices (Noah in 8:20; Abraham in 12:4-10) and passes on the blessing and right of the first-born (Gen. 27).

In Genesis 4:3, we're told first that Cain brought his offering. Then, all of a sudden, we're told, "And Abel, he also brought from the firstborn of his flocks ..."

If Abel's offering is not an effort at usurpation of his elder brother (and it may well be), the narrator is at least showing us that the first-born is being shown up by his younger brother. And to top it all off, Yahweh favors Abel!

This begins a major theme in the book of Genesis: that God carries forward his promises in ways that subvert and challenge traditional wisdom in human societies, and he loves to elevate the underdog and the disadvantaged.

Sacrifices at the Door of the Garden

Cain and Abel are introduced in a narrative about worship as they make their offerings before Yahweh. But where is this story taking place?

- Genesis 3:22-24 tells us that the humans were sent out from the garden of Eden "to the east" and that on that eastern border of Eden, Yahweh stationed cherubim and a sword.
- When Cain is exiled after murdering his brother in Genesis 4:16, we're told he went "east of Eden." This means that Genesis 4:1-16 is taking place within Eden, near the eastern edge of the garden.
- There are numerous clues in this narrative and in later design patterns about the tabernacle and temple that point to envisioning this offering as taking place at the "door" of the garden of Eden, which is mentioned in Genesis 4:7.

The "door" of Genesis 4:7 is often taken to metaphorically refer to the door of Cain's heart or mind, where the sinful urge is waiting for him. But this is not what the Hebrew text says. Genesis 4:7 consists of three words in Hebrew: "at the door" (לפתח), sin (חטאת) is a croucher (רביץ). The metaphorical "door of the heart" is used nowhere else in the Hebrew Bible, whereas the narrative context provides us with a perfectly plausible explanation.

Cain and Abel are depicted as offering their sacrifices at the door of the garden of Eden, in front of the cherubim and the entrance into the holy place of God's heavenly presence on Earth. The sinful, animal-like temptation to rebel against God has exited the garden with them and is now "at the door" alongside them.

With this reading, the later tabernacle and temple mirror this precise scene, as the altar was placed directly east in front of the "door" (פתח) to the sacred space, where offerings were made before the priests could enter into sacred space.

Resource Recommendation

For more on topic of sacrifices at the door of Eden, see Azevedo, J (1999). "At the Door of Paradise: A Contextual Interpretation of Genesis 4:7." *Biblische Notizen*, vol. 100.

Reflection Question

Is there something wrong with Cain's offering? Was Cain rejected by God?